

Week 8: Design Patterns in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Bible stories separated by centuries sometimes echo each other on purpose — tonight we'll look at how to start spotting those connections.

1. Have you ever noticed a movie or show deliberately echo an earlier scene — the same shot, the same line, the same choice — to make a point by comparison? What did that repetition make you think or feel?
2. **Read Genesis 3:6-7.** What three things does the text say Eve does, in order, before she eats the fruit? Keep that sequence in mind as we look at a few more stories.
3. **Read Genesis 16:1-6.** Sarai gives Hagar to Abram, and the same basic pattern of desiring and taking something outside of God's promise plays out again. What's different about the players here, and what's exactly the same?
4. **Read Exodus 32:1-22.** What do the Israelites ask Aaron to make for them, and what does he do with the gold they bring him? What kind of consequences does one person's — or one community's — moment of temptation end up creating for everyone around them?
5. **Read 2 Samuel 11:1-5.** What does David see from his roof, and what does he do about it? By this point, this pattern should feel familiar. Why do you think the biblical authors wanted you to recognize it here too?
6. This same "see, desire, take" pattern shows up with Adam and Eve, Abraham and Sarai, Aaron and Israel, and David — completely different characters spread across a huge span of time. What does this pattern suggest about the biblical authors' view of human nature?
7. The Gospels tell us that when Jesus faced his own moment of temptation in the garden of Gethsemane, he prayed "not my desire, but yours be done" — flipping the pattern for the first time in the whole story. Why does it matter that this reversal

happens through suffering and surrender rather than through Jesus simply getting what he wanted?

8. Where do you see this "see it, want it, take it" pattern playing out in your own life or in the temptations you regularly face?
9. Knowing how intentionally these patterns were woven across so many different books and centuries, how does that shape your confidence in the Bible as one coordinated story rather than a loose collection of unrelated books?